



pleasant. So, if I were to come back and play, I'd need a clear purpose. I'm not someone who would return just for the sake of it and play only four or five games. What's the point?

Everyone says, "Come back, we want you," but if I only play five games, will that really help Bangladesh cricket?

If there's a proper plan in place regarding what they want to achieve, then I can consider it and we can have a discussion. But right now, you're talking about the Champions Trophy, where there are only four or five ODIs, and three in the West Indies. So essentially, we're talking about just six or seven games. Since I've stepped back and someone else has taken my place, it doesn't make sense to return for just a handful of matches.

However, it's a different story if the BCB says they want to win the Champions Trophy or at least aim for the semifinals, and that this will likely be the last tournament for three or four senior players, regardless of past differences, and that the BCB

Imminent return?: New BCB president Faruque Ahmed wants to see Tamim Iqbal return to international cricket. AFP

will work to resolve any issues. That's the right way to approach things.

If such a request comes your way, will you consider it?

Yes, of course. But the question is: do I play for the cricket board, or do I play for the team? Where should the request come from? The cricket board looks after me, but the players also need to be welcoming.

I have a good relationship with everyone, so I know that won't be an issue. But, for example, if I were the captain and wanted to achieve something, I would talk to you, share my vision and plan, and convince you to join me on that journey. If needed, I'd also assure you that everything would be taken care of.

Me joining the team and you wanting me in the team are two different things. If a situation arises where both the team and I feel that my presence is necessary, then I'll consider it.

Coming back to Shakib, do you think that this was the right time for him to announce retirement?

A lot is written about in the media and on social media, and people discuss various issues. Everyone — be it the captain, the coach, or the Board — has their own opinion. However, when you truly feel that it's time to step away, you do so accordingly.

If he has heard that call from within, then he has certainly made the right decision, and we should all respect that.

Having played together for a long time, is there any particular

memory with Shakib that you'll always cherish?

It was in 2009. We were participating in a tri-nation tournament alongside Sri Lanka and Zimbabwe in Dhaka. We lost our first game against Zimbabwe, and to reach the final, we needed to beat Sri Lanka with a bonus point. It was a rain-curtailed match of 31 overs per side, and Bangladesh had to chase down Sri Lanka's total of 147 within 25 overs to secure that bonus point.

Back then, winning games with a bonus point was beyond our imagination. We were struggling at 11 for 3 when Shakib walked out to bat. He played an unbelievable knock — an unbeaten 92 off 69 balls — to guide the team home in just 23.5 overs. Not only did we win the game, but we also reached the final with a bonus point.

Sitting in the dressing room, I knew there was a chance to win, but I couldn't have imagined that we would achieve that with a bonus point. However, Shakib had a different mindset. I genuinely feel that unbeaten 92 was the best-ever ODI innings by a Bangladesh cricketer. That's Shakib Al Hasan for you. His ability to think differently has shaped him into who he is today. I rate that innings very, very highly.

With Shakib stepping away from Tests and T20Is for now, how challenging will it be to fill his gap? Does Bangladesh have enough talent to replace him?

Replacing someone like me, Shakib, or Mushfiq isn't easy. It won't happen overnight. We have played the game for 17 years, so this will take time. However, the reality is that time doesn't wait for anyone. Eventually, someone will come along to fill that spot. I'm not saying it will never happen; it may happen, but it will take time.

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